

AVEC

# A framework for strong relationships

BECAUSE MEANINGFUL  
CONNECTIONS FUEL A  
HAPPIER, MORE RESILIENT  
LIFE.

## The secrets of strong connections

Our ability to cultivate strong relationships plays an important role in our learning, well-being, and resilience. At the same time, many of us have room to strengthen our connections with others. As you watch this video, ask yourself:



01

How strong are my  
relationships in  
general?



02

Which specific  
relationships could  
be strengthened?



Enhances  
learning



Supports  
well-being



Builds  
resilience



Creates a  
stronger support  
network

# A framework for strong relationships

PEOPLE THRIVE WHEN WE GENUINELY SEE, HEAR, AND SUPPORT EACH OTHER.

## We can develop strong, energizing relationships **by practicing AVEC**

We can develop strong, energizing relationships by practicing AVEC: attention, vulnerability, empathy, and compassion. We refer to these characteristics as “not-so-secret secrets” because although they seem obvious, it is the regularity and nuance with which we practice them that leads to genuinely strong connections.



### Attention

Be fully present and give genuine focus to others.



### Vulnerability

Be open and authentic, and willing to share your true thoughts and feelings.



### Empathy

Seek to understand others' perspectives and feelings.



### Compassion

Care about others and take meaningful actions to support them.



These are “not-so-secret secrets” — they may seem obvious, but it is the regularity and nuance with which we practice them that leads to genuinely strong connections.

# What each element looks like in practice?

The four elements of AVEC complement each other and can be practiced in everyday life to build stronger, more energized, and more meaningful relationships.



## Attention

Turning toward the other person literally and figuratively, and listening deeply without judgment, distraction, or the desire to respond.



Truly listen without interrupting.



Minimize distractions (e.g., put your phone away).



Show genuine interest through thoughtful questions and body language.



## Empathy

Understanding and identifying with the emotions and perspectives of others, based on what they share with you.



Try to see the situation from the other person's perspective.



Acknowledge their feelings, even if they are different from your own experience.



Respond in a way that shows understanding, not just providing solutions.



## Vulnerability

Being your authentic self, even if it feels outside of your comfort zone.



Share your thoughts, feelings, or experiences honestly.



Acknowledge your mistakes or uncertainties without fear of judgment.



Show your true self as a way to build trust and deepen connection.



## Compassion

Demonstrating genuine care with an intention to be helpful and taking action to support others.



Check in on others and ask how they are doing.



Invest your time, energy, or resources to support them.



Offer consistent support, especially during challenging times.

